DID YOU KNOW?

The artist Subodh Gupta, best known for his gigantic sculptures assembled from hundreds of steel kitchen utensils, has also incorporated 'performances' of cooking and serving meals to accompany or sometimes eat inside his installations

in the value and reputation of artists of the first generation—the 'Progressives' and all those who followed. In 2005, Tyeb Mehta's 'Mahisasura' went for a million US dollars (Rs 8.5 crore) at Christies, and since then the boom has continued, past a series of milestones—from Raza's 'Saurashtra' hitting $3.48 million (Rs 29.5 crore) in 2010, an untitled Gaitonde for $5.5 million (Rs 46.6 crore) in 2021. Living artists have benefitted too—notably Subodh Gupta, who joined the million-dollar league in 2008, when an installation featuring his inevitable steel vessels sold for $1.2 million (Rs 10.2 crore) at yet another Christie's auction.


Brush with India

Sotheby's and Christie's help put Indian art on global map

FROM THE ARCHIVES
May 31, 1995

The Arts **Brush with India**

For the first auction of contemporary art last year, Indian buyers rushed to London because the estimated prices for Husains were much lower than they are in India.

Sotheby's first realised the potential of the market for contemporary Indian art during its auction in India in 1992. "Our sales in this section surprised us. We sold 82 per cent of what we had." But the Indians may now have others eyeing that hammer as well...
–Madhu Jain



₹61.8 CRORE

'The Storyteller' (1937) by Amrita Sher-Gil, sold at a Saffronart auction (Sept. '23)



₹51.75 CRORE

'Gestation' (1989) by S.H. Raza at Pundole's auction (Sept. '23)

Inevitably, entry into the global art market has been marked by the roller coaster fortunes of international finance (and financiers who buy the art). Thus the first 'boom' in the India art market ended in 2008 when prices fell off a cliff (no prizes for guessing). But business as usual was soon restored; by 2015, both the big international auctioneers had begun holding their sales of contemporary Indian art in Mumbai. And while Christie's would pull out again in 2017, a number of Indian auction houses had by then established themselves as serious players. Likewise, India's plutocracy had acquired an art habit, and names like the Ambanis, the Nadars and the Poddars have become synonymous with art patronage and philanthropy.

Today, the unofficial title of 'most expensive work of modern Indian art' belongs to 'The Storytellers', a 1937 painting by Amrita Sher-Gil, which sold at a Saffronart auction in New Delhi in September 2023 for a reported Rs 61.8 crore. That's a Cattelan banana—and a chunk of change. ■

A LARGER CANVAS NOW

» 1995: In June, Sotheby's has an auction of contemporary Indian art from the Herwitz collection in NYC

» 1995: Christie's hosts sale of 20th century Indian art sale in London in Dec.

» 2000: Indian art auction houses, Osian and Saffron Art, established

» 2008: The first India Art Fair (originally 'Art Summit') in New Delhi, becomes an annual affair

» 2010: KNMA (Kiran Nadar Museum of Art), the first private museum exhibiting modern and contemporary Indian art, opens in Delhi

» 2013: Christie's holds its first contemporary art auction in Mumbai

» 2015: Sotheby's opens its India office, holds first auction at the Taj Mumbai

» 2023: Abhishek Poddar's Museum of Art and Photography opens in Bengaluru